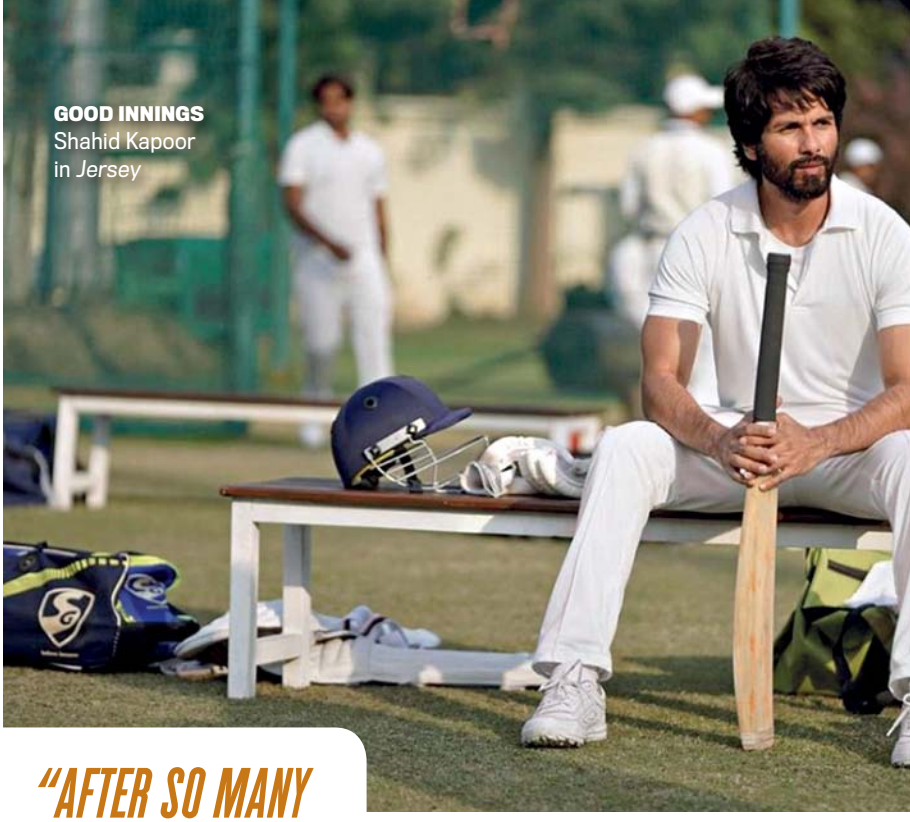


GOOD INNINGS
Shahid Kapoor in *Jersey*

It was after 18 years of being in the profession that Shahid Kapoor experienced a kind of high that most actors only dream of. His last release, *Kabir Singh*, grossed Rs 276 crore, making it the most successful Hindi film of 2019. The film's stupendous success, says Kapoor, "settled" him. "I felt it was due, man. When it happened, I felt fine and happy, and I felt a lot of gratitude." Almost overnight, the industry's attitude towards him changed. Karan Johar began inviting him to his A-lister house parties. There were reports of how Kapoor had hiked his fee, of how he was now being courted by big banners. "I was the same guy, the same actor," Kapoor says. "But people always react to success more than quality. It is just the way our fraternity works and there's nothing wrong with that."

Two and a half years later, Kapoor is hoping to add to his success with yet another Hindi remake of a popular Telugu film. *Jersey*, which releases in cinemas on April 22, sees the actor play a 36-year-old unemployed husband and father who, after hanging up his gloves, decides to give cricket another shot. Much like Kabir Singh, Kapoor feels Arjun Talwar is a very "potent" character, which required him to tap into those reservoirs of angst again. "I saw *Jersey* a week before *Kabir Singh's* release. I felt very motivated and emotionally charged. I deeply connected with [Arjun] and the meaningful message [the film] gives," says Kapoor. "*Jersey* is very cathartic, yet very uplifting, which is rare. If I can make people feel the way I felt when I saw the film, I will be proud I was part of it."

> "AFTER SO MANY YEARS OF WORK, IT IS IMPORTANT TO BREAK AWAY AND TRY A DIFFERENT FORMAT"

Jersey, like *Kabir Singh*, has also been directed by the maker of the original. Kapoor appreciates the fact that both filmmakers—Sandeep Reddy Vanga (*Kabir Singh*) and Gowtam Tinnanuri (*Jersey*)—were comfortable enough with Hindi to want to rediscover an existing story "in a different milieu". He says, "I feel *Kabir Singh* in the hands of a filmmaker other than Sandeep could have come across as a negative character. Gowtam also deeply understands the character and presents his internal point of view."

Though it remains to be seen how audiences will respond to Kapoor's second consecutive remake, the actor, for now, is already making evident his somewhat large appetite for experimentation. Not just was Kapoor one of the first of his generation to sign up for a web show, the fact that he chose to do so after just having enjoyed his biggest theatrical success surprised many. Raj and DK, the directing duo behind the successful *The Family Man* (2019—), were apparently "shocked" when Kapoor asked them if instead of a film, they had an idea for a series he could be made a part of.

For Kapoor, who spent a large chunk of 2020 enjoying OTT content, it seemed like a step in the right direction. "After so many years of work, it is important to break away and try a different format, to challenge yourself in a different way," he says. "I have no fear of failure, of taking risks, and rejection. My only fear is that I will get bored of what I do." Kapoor is looking